

Elegant tower is a milestone in university's transformation

By Robert Campbell

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

The new student tower at Northeastern University, by architect William Rawn, is the most elegant high-rise in Boston since the Hancock Tower of a generation ago.

Students who moved into the slim, 20-story building this month found themselves in a structure that feels like a vertical shaft of light.

It takes a while to figure out the trick. It's the two short wings that project out at both sides. Each of these wings contains, on each floor, the living room of a student apartment. When you look at the tower from the street, you're looking south, and because the sun is generally in the south, daylight flows toward you through those two glass wings, so that the

whole tower seems to glow from within. "Luminescent" is the word used by Northeastern's president, Richard Freeland.

The luminescence is ingenious, but there's a lot more to admire about this building. A good architect makes the most of the natural character of materials. Glass is flat, taut, and transparent, and so is the facade of this building. The steel mullions that frame the glass are taut too, as crisp and sharp as ink lines ruled on the facade. This is glass at its glassiest.

Move around to the side, and the building reveals more of itself. The glass, it turns out, is only a frontispiece, 15 feet deep, a sort of starched formal shirt front the building puts on where it meets the city. Behind it is more conventional, less expensive archi-

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A narrow glass frontispiece distinguishes the facade of a 20-story tower designed by architect William Rawn as part of Northeastern University's new West Campus.



PHOTO/ALAN KARCHMER

*'West Campus signals a new institution.
Building H symbolizes the change.'*

RICHARD FREELAND, Northeastern University president

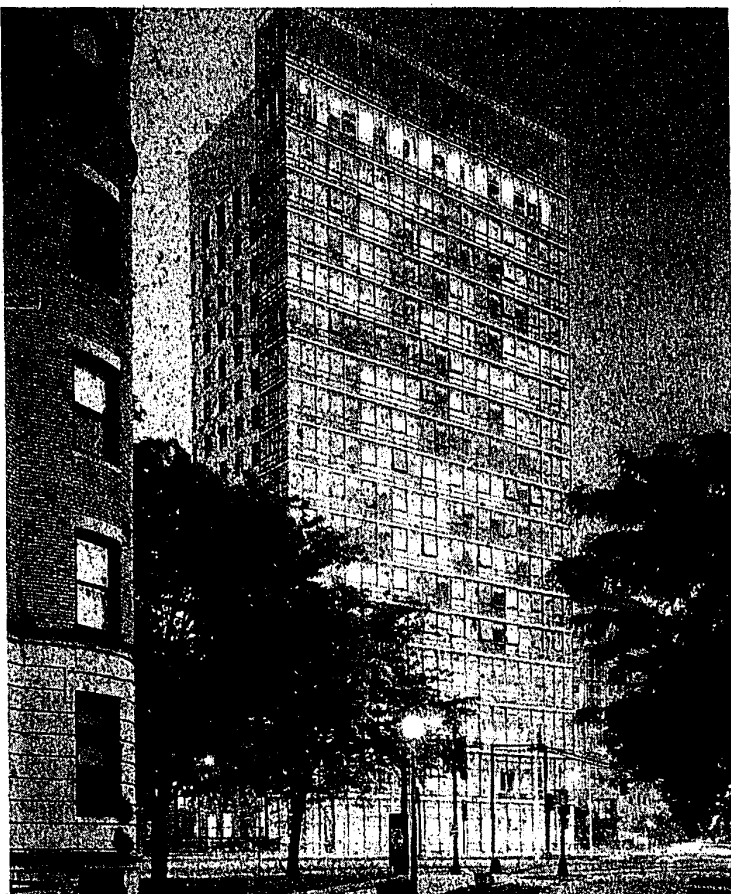
Slender tower makes an eloquent statement

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ture, though still handsome. This more conventional rear is carved back from the glass front at the top of the building, leaving the glass tower to rise free as a recognizable icon, like a bell tower. It faces the proposed new wing of the Museum of Fine Arts across Huntington. The tower will, it is hoped, signal the presence of a new and revitalized Northeastern in the larger urban context.

The building is still nameless. Northeastern calls it Building H. (Any donors out there?) It is, of course, much more than an elegant architectural statement. It also provides accommodation for human activity. Here again, Building H is a winner. Rooms are gathered into suites, each with four single bedrooms, a living room, and a kitchen. These spaces are generously proportioned by dorm standards, and they enjoy great views. Building H feels almost like luxury housing. Total cost was \$47 million, a little under \$300 per square foot.

Only the upper floors are dorms. The bottom four are home to Northeastern's College of Computer and Information Science, with classrooms, labs, and offices. Freeland believes in mixing uses in unexpected places, so students and faculty will move around the campus, animating the paths and



PHOTO/ALAN KARCHMER

Daylight flows through the wings of the glass facade in a new tower at Northeastern, so the whole building can appear to glow from within.

quads and meeting one another. What's a little weird about Building H is that the computer college not only fills the lower floors of the tower, it also extends outward from the tower as a low-rise appendage. It seems to work fine inside, but its exterior doesn't equal the quality of the tower. The fa-

cade along Huntington is cluttered with canopies and fins that seem needless and have a retro, 1950s look.

Building H is a further milestone in the amazing transformation of Northeastern from a commuter school, with a campus that seemed to be made mostly of black

asphalt, into an attractive university. There are fewer students now and more of them live on campus, creating a sense of community that never existed before. Building H is part of the new West Campus, for which Rawn did the master plan and for which he designed a pleasant quad of orange brick dorms. Freeland believes that without the transformation, Northeastern would have gone under. Dependent as it is on tuition, it could no longer compete with state-supported institutions such as the University of Massachusetts. He notes that Northeastern has risen in six years from 165th to 120th among US colleges in the US News and World Report annual poll. He's aiming for the top 100.

"West Campus signals a new institution," says Freeland. "Building H symbolizes the change. It's tall, it's generous."

Building H is also a milestone in the career of Rawn, who first became known as the hero of a book called "House" by Tracy Kidder and later designed Ozawa Hall for the Boston Symphony Orchestra at Tanglewood. Ozawa Hall, in a recent worldwide survey of musicians, was named the world's 13th best concert hall and one of the six best of the 20th century. Building H is another gem in this architect's career.

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Critics' Picks: Theater

Opening

"THE KING AND I" — Sandy Duncan goes Siamese. Preview on Tuesday, opens Wednesday, closes Sunday at the Wang Theatre. 800-447-7400, www.wangcenter.org.

"RICHARD III" — The Actors' Shakespeare Project, a stellar group of local thespians, takes over the Old South Meeting House with John Kuntz in the title role. Previews begin Thursday, opens Saturday, closes Nov. 7. 866-811-4111; actorsshakespeareproject.org.

"COMPANY" — SpeakEasy Stage Company inaugurates the Nancy and Edward Roberts Studio Theatre in the new Stanford Calderwood Pavilion at the Boston Center for the Arts with the Stephen Sondheim classic. Previews on Friday night and Saturday afternoon, opens Saturday night, closes Nov. 13. 617-933-8600; www.speakeasystage.com, www.bostontheatrescene.com.

Now playing

"GEM OF THE OCEAN" — Phylicia Rashad is mesmerizing as the spiritual embodiment of three centuries of African-American history in August Wilson's excellent new play. Through Oct. 30. 617-266-0800, www.huntingtontheatre.org.

ED SIEGEL

"A LITTLE NIGHT MUSIC" — The Lyric Stage Company strikes Sondheim paydirt again, this time with a sparkling chamber version of the charming musical. Maryann Zschau, Christopher Chew, Drew Poling, and Leigh Barrett head a very strong ensemble. Through Oct. 16. 617-437-7172; www.lyricstage.com.

E.S.

"PRIVATE JOKES, PUBLIC PLACES" — Oren Safdie's very smart and entertaining satire of the architecture world finds just the right building — the Wellfleet Harbor Actors Theater. Through Oct. 24. 508-349-6835; www.what.org.

E.S.

"THE LION KING" — Julie Taymor's staging of the Disney fable gives the reopened Opera House a certain pride of place. Through Dec. 26. 617-931-2787; www.broadwayinboston.com.

E.S.

For complete listings, visit ae.boston.com/events.

Critics' Picks: Classical Music

MEZZO-SOPRANO MITSUKO SHIRAI AND PIANIST HARTMUT HOELL perform Mahler songs Tuesday at 8 p.m. in Harvard Epworth Church. The program includes "Kindertotenlieder," "Songs of a Wayfarer," and "Der Abschied" from "Das Lied von der Erde." 617-496-2222.

THE BOSTON PHILHARMONIC, led by Benjamin Zander, continues its "Mahler Journey" of last season, with performances of the Adagio from the 10th Symphony and "Das Lied von der Erde," with mezzo Gigi Mitchell-Velasco and tenor Thomas Young. On Thursday at 7:30 in Sanders Theatre, Saturday at 8 in Jordan Hall, and next Sunday at 3 in Sanders Theatre. 617-236-0999; www.bostonphil.org.

THE HANDEL & HAYDN SOCIETY and conductor Grant Llewellyn perform Mozart's C-Minor Mass and other works by Mozart and Haydn Friday at 8 p.m. and next Sunday at 3 p.m. in Symphony Hall. 617-266-3605. www.handelandhaydn.org.

OPERA BOSTON presents performances of Offenbach's operetta "La Vie Parisienne" in the Cutler Majestic Theatre Friday at 7:30 p.m. and next Sunday at 3 p.m. 800-233-3123; www.telecharge.com.

THE BOSTON CHAMBER MUSIC SOCIETY opens its season with an all-Beethoven program including the "Kreutzer" Sonata and the "Storm" Quintet Friday at 7:30 p.m. in Jordan Hall and next Sunday at 7:30 p.m. in Sanders Theatre. 617-349-0086; www.bostonchambermusic.org.

EMMA KIRKBY, the popular and much-recorded British early-music diva, joins the viol ensemble Fretwork in English consort songs of the 16th and 17th centuries, presented by the Boston Early Music Festival in Paine Hall Saturday at 8. 617-661-1812; www.bemf.org.

THE NEW ENGLAND STRING ENSEMBLE, led by Susan Davenny Wyner, presents Mozart, Mahler, Dvorak, and Britten's dramatic cantata "Phaedra" Friday at 8 p.m. in First Parish Church in Wakefield and next Sunday at 3 p.m. in Jordan Hall. 781-224-1117; www.newenglandstringensemble.org.

RICHARD DYER

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